

Application prep — United States: 6 universities

Sample — anonymized demo. This is a real end-to-end search with the student's identity removed (name changed, school and personal finances generalized). It shows the format and depth you get, not a real person's private file.

How to use this guide. This is your **action list** for applying to these universities — the deadlines, tests, essays, fees, and financial-aid forms, with the shared work grouped so you do it once. It is *not* a "which university is best for me?" guide (that's your dossiers). Work top to bottom: read the strategy, skim [Key terms](#) if the shorthand is new, then work each checklist. **Tap any linked term to jump to its plain-English meaning, and use the Contents to jump around.**

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Key terms

New to these? Here's what the shorthand in this guide means — tap a linked term anywhere below to jump back here.

- **ED — Early Decision** — apply early and, if admitted, you are *bound* to enrol and withdraw your other applications. Avoid it if you need to compare aid offers.
- **EA — Early Action** — apply early for an earlier decision; *non-binding*, so you stay free to compare offers and decline.
- **RD — Regular Decision** — the standard round with the normal (later) deadline; non-binding.
- **SCEA — Single-Choice Early Action** — a restrictive early option: non-binding, but you may not apply early to most *other* private universities at the same time.
- **REA — Restrictive Early Action** — like SCEA: non-binding early action that bars you from applying early to other private schools.
- **cost of attendance** — The university's official all-in yearly price — tuition **plus** housing, food, fees, books and personal expenses. This is the number financial aid is measured against, not the tuition figure alone.
- **demonstrated need** — Your cost of attendance minus what the university calculates your family can pay. "Meets 100% of need" means it covers that gap — it does not automatically mean you pay nothing, so check what's left for you.
- **student contribution** — The amount a US aid package expects *you* (not your parents) to contribute each year, usually from summer or term-time campus work. It is part of the package, so it is not covered by the grant.
- **need-blind** — The university decides admission *without* looking at whether you asked for financial aid — requesting aid can't hurt your chances.
- **need-aware** — Your ability to pay *can* factor into the admission decision — you still request aid, but it is a consideration.
- **CSS Profile** — The College Board's detailed financial-aid application most US universities use to assess your need (separate from the FAFSA). Opens 1 October.
- **IDOC** — College Board's Institutional Documentation Service — where you upload your parents' tax/income documents for financial aid.
- **PFAA — Princeton Financial Aid Application** — Princeton's own aid form, filed alongside the CSS Profile.
- **ISAFSA — International Student Financial Aid Application** — Stanford's alternative aid form if you can't pay the CSS Profile fee.
- **fee waiver** — A request to cancel the application fee on the grounds of financial need — so you pay nothing to apply.
- **Common App** — The Common Application — one online form plus one main essay you reuse across many US universities.
- **self-report** — You type your own test scores into the application; you only pay to send official scores once you enrol.
- **supplement** — Extra, school-specific essay(s) on top of the shared Common App essay.

- **School Report** — A form (plus a letter) your school counsellor submits about you and your school.
- **mid-year report** — An update your school sends partway through the year with your latest grades.
- **I-20** — The US immigration form your university issues after you're admitted — you need it to apply for a student visa.
- **SAT** — A standardised US university-entrance exam; many US universities require the SAT or the ACT.
- **ACT** — A standardised US university-entrance exam; an accepted alternative to the SAT.
- **IELTS** — International English Language Testing System — an English-proficiency test. Your English-medium A-Levels waive it at many universities, but not all.
- **TOEFL** — Test of English as a Foreign Language — an English-proficiency test; an alternative to IELTS.
- **JPA** — Malaysian government overseas-study sponsorship (JPA / MARA, via the PKJM programme) — a route to full funding for eligible students.
- **Yayasan Khazanah** — A Malaysian foundation offering competitive scholarships to study at top global universities.

Snapshot

- **Region:** United States
- **Universities:** 6
- **Common App:** Princeton University, Stanford University, University of Pennsylvania (UPenn), Harvard University, Yale University
- **MIT application (own portal, NOT Common App):** Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)

United States application strategy

The set: 6 US universities, applied through **2 systems** — **5 on the Common App** (Princeton, Stanford, UPenn, Harvard, Yale) and **MIT on its own portal** (not the Common App).

One honest caveat (your call): all 6 are **extreme Reaches (~3–6% admit)** — there is no Match or Safety in this US set. You chose to keep the US to these six; the realistic-odds balance comes from your other regions (UK/Australia/Singapore). Applying is still worth it because, for your income band, the aid makes them effectively free **if** admitted.

1. You get ONE early card — spend it well

The restrictive early programs each **bar you from applying early anywhere else private**, including MIT's [Early Action](#): - **Restrictive early (pick at most ONE):** Princeton [SCEA](#) · Stanford [REA](#) · Harvard [REA](#) · Yale [SCEA](#) — all non-binding, but each blocks every other private early app. - **MIT Early Action** is non-restrictive on MIT's side, but the four restrictive schools above won't let you pair their early with

it — so in practice MIT EA is *also* a one-or-nothing early choice. - **UPenn's only early option is binding [Early Decision](#) → unsuitable** for you (you must compare aid offers). **Apply Penn via [Regular Decision](#).**

So: exactly one early application, everything else Regular Decision. Recommendation → spend the early card on *Princeton SCEA* ([need-blind](#), and test-optional this cycle, so you can submit Nov 1 without waiting on an [SAT](#) sitting) or *MIT EA* (need-blind, but forces the SAT by Nov 30). Both are need-blind, so requesting aid can't hurt you. Everything else RD.

2. Tests — book the SAT now (your main lead-time gate)

- **SAT/ACT REQUIRED:** MIT, Stanford, UPenn, Harvard, Yale. (*Yale newly requires it — its old test-flexible AP/IB route ended for this cycle.*)
- **Princeton is test-optional** for Fall-2027 entry (its requirement returns Fall-2028) — you may still submit, but you don't have to.
- **When to sit it:** for an **early** app, take the SAT by **3 Oct 2026** (Stanford REA needs an end-Oct score; Harvard REA by end-Nov; MIT EA by 30 Nov). For **Regular Decision**, by **5 Dec 2026**. Fall-2026 SAT dates: **Aug 22 · Sep 12 · Oct 3 · Nov 7 · Dec 5** (all offered internationally). Scores are **self-reported** on every application — no need to pay to send official scores until you enroll.
- **IELTS/TOEFL: NOT required at any of the six** — your English-medium A-Levels waive it. (You still need IELTS for Singapore / China / Australia — that's a separate lead-time item.)

3. Aid model — always request it, but know the two tiers (your #1 priority)

What "100% of need" is 100% of: the [cost of attendance](#) — the university's whole yearly price, not just tuition. For your six that is **USD 92,760–99,082/yr (~RM 378,000–404,000/yr)**: MIT cheapest, Penn priciest. Your [demonstrated need](#) is that figure minus what your family is judged able to pay — and at a lower-income band household income, every one of these six judges your parents' share to be **USD 0**. So "meets 100% of need" here really does mean **~RM 400k/yr covered, if admitted**, with grants and **no loans**.

But "free" isn't literally free — you have a share. Five of the six expect *you* to contribute a few thousand USD a year from campus work: **Stanford ~USD 5,000 · Yale USD 3,700 · Harvard ~USD 2,700–3,500** (term-time only — no summer work) · **MIT** summer savings + term work (amount unpublished) · **Penn** unpublished. **Princeton alone expects nothing** — it abolished its [student contribution](#) in 2022. Flights, winter gear and health insurance are **covered at Harvard and Yale**; elsewhere they sit inside a travel allowance you should confirm. The US **visa + SEVIS fees are always yours**.

The other difference is whether *asking* for aid can affect admission: - **Need-BLIND for internationals (ask freely, zero penalty): MIT · Princeton · Harvard · Yale.** - **Need-AWARE for internationals (ability to pay is a factor): Stanford · UPenn.** You must still request aid (you need it) — just know a Malaysian-sponsor hedge ([JPA](#) / [Yayasan Khazanah](#)) matters more for these two. **Penn: aid MUST be requested WITH the application — it cannot be added after admission.**

4. Fees — your US application-fee outlay is ~USD 0

- **No application fee for international applicants: Harvard · Yale · MIT · Princeton.**

- **Stanford USD 90 · Penn USD 75** — both offer **need-based fee waivers** (request via the Common App or the school). Request them; budget ~USD 0.

5. Financial-aid forms cheat-sheet

- **CSS Profile** — needed by **all six**; opens **1 Oct 2026**.
- Plus, per school: **Princeton** → PFAA ([Princeton Financial Aid Application](#)) + CSS. **Harvard & MIT** → CSS + **IDOC** (upload parent tax/income docs). **Stanford** → CSS, or **ISAF** if you can't pay the CSS fee. **UPenn** → CSS (Penn code **2933**) filed **with** the application.
- **Gather now:** parents' **income + tax documents**, translated to English — every aid form needs them.

Grouped by application system

Common App

Universities: Princeton University, Stanford University, University of Pennsylvania (UPenn), Harvard University, Yale University.

Filed once across these schools:

- ☐ **Common App account** + the **Common App personal essay** (~650 words) — written once, reused across all 5 Common App schools.
- ☐ **School Report** + **counselor recommendation** (your school counselor).
- ☐ **Two teacher recommendations** — ideally 1 maths/science + 1 other subject. (*The same recommenders can also cover MIT.*)
- ☐ **Official transcript** (your school) + **predicted A-Level grades**; send a **mid-year report** when available.
- ☐ Each school's **own supplement essays + application fee** (see per-school below).
- ☐ **Self-report SAT** where required (all except Princeton, which is test-optional this cycle).
- ☐ Fee waivers requested through the Common App where a fee applies (Stanford, Penn).

1. Princeton University — Reach — need-blind for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** [SCEA 2026-11-01](#) · [Regular Decision 2027-01-01](#)
- **Financial-aid deadline:** File with the application; RD aid documents by early Feb 2027 (confirm exact date on Princeton's aid page).

b. Tests

- **Test-OPTIONAL** for Fall-2027 entry — no SAT/[ACT](#) needed (you may submit; Princeton reports submitters do well).
- [IELTS/TOEFL](#) **waived** (English-medium A-Levels).

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay + Princeton supplement** (a graded written paper + several short answers).
- 2026-27 prompts publish when the Common App opens ~1 Aug 2026 — confirm then.

d. Application fee

- **No application fee** for international applicants (low-income applicants are auto-eligible for Princeton's waiver).

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model** — [Need-blind for internationals](#) — requesting aid does **not** affect admission. Princeton is one of under ten US universities that puts **no cap on international aid**.
- **Cost** — **USD 94,624/yr** all-in for a first-year (~**RM 386,000/yr**) — tuition 68,140 · housing 13,010 · food 9,110 · fees 314 · books 1,050 · personal 3,000. Travel is added on top (USD 50–5,000, set by your home address). The Student Health Plan is a further USD 4,220 unless your family's insurance covers you.
- **Covers** — **All of it, for your band**. Under ~USD 100k family income (you're a lower-income band): full tuition + **housing + food + books + personal expenses**, with **zero family contribution** — grants only, **no loans**. Not a discount: the whole ~RM 386k/yr.
- **Your share**
 - **Nothing from your parents**, and **nothing from you** — Princeton **abolished its USD 3,500 student contribution in 2022** for *all* undergraduates, so there is no summer-savings or campus-job expectation.
 - Travel sits inside the [cost of attendance](#) (USD 50–5,000 by address), so it is part of what aid is measured against.
 - **Still yours**: the US visa + SEVIS fees, and your own spending beyond the allowance. *Confirm with Princeton whether the travel allowance stretches to a Malaysia–US airfare.*
- **Forms** — [Princeton Financial Aid Application \(PFAA\)](#) + [CSS Profile](#).
- **Documents** — Parents' income + tax documents.

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Common App + Princeton supplement
- ☐ counselor + 2 teacher recs
- ☐ transcript + predicted grades
- ☐ (SAT optional)
- ☐ PFAA + CSS Profile + parent tax docs

Portal: <https://admission.princeton.edu/apply> · aid: <https://admission.princeton.edu/cost-aid/apply-financial-aid>

2. Stanford University — Reach — need-AWARE for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** [REA](#) **2026-11-01** · Regular Decision **2027-01-05**
- **Financial-aid deadline:** REA aid **priority 2026-11-15** (notification mid-Dec); RD aid filed with the application.

b. Tests

- **SAT/ACT REQUIRED.** REA: SAT by end **Oct 2026**; RD: by end **Dec 2026**. Self-reported.
- IELTS/TOEFL **waived** (English-medium A-Levels).

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay + Stanford supplement** (several short questions + short essays).
- Confirm 2026-27 prompts at Common App open (~1 Aug 2026).

d. Application fee

- **USD 90**, or a **need-based [fee waiver](#)** (request via the Common App / Stanford).

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model** — [Need-AWARE for internationals](#) — ability to pay factors into admission (limited international-aid budget). Still request aid (you need it); a Malaysian-sponsor hedge matters more here.
- **Cost** — **USD 97,545/yr** all-in (~**RM 398,000/yr**) — tuition 67,731 · housing + food 22,944 · fees 2,610 · books 855 · personal 3,405. Travel is added on top and varies by address.
- **Covers** — **100% of [demonstrated need](#)** if you're admitted with aid. For your band (a lower-income band), parents earning under USD 100k with typical assets pay **no tuition, no housing, no food** — a **USD 0 parent contribution** against that ~RM 398k.
- **Your share**
 - **~USD 5,000/yr from you** (~RM 20,000) — the highest student contribution of your six: about **USD 1,500 from prior/summer earnings + USD 3,500 from a term-time job** (8–10 hrs/week at Stanford's USD 15+/hr campus minimum). This is part of the package, not a bill you can ignore.
 - **Still yours:** visa + SEVIS fees, and spending beyond the allowance.
- **Forms** — **CSS Profile**, or [ISAFA](#) if you can't pay the CSS fee.
- **Documents** — Parents' income + tax documents.

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Common App + Stanford supplement
- ☐ counselor + 2 teacher recs
- ☐ transcript + predicted grades
- ☐ **SAT (self-report)**
- ☐ CSS Profile/ISAFA + parent tax docs

- ☐ request fee waiver

Portal: <https://admission.stanford.edu/apply> · aid: <https://financialaid.stanford.edu/undergrad/apply/>

3. University of Pennsylvania (UPenn) — Reach — need-AWARE for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline: Apply Regular Decision — 2027-01-05.** (Penn's only early option is *binding ED* — avoid it; you must compare aid offers.)
- **Financial-aid deadline: Must be requested WITH the application — cannot be added after admission.** CSS Profile opens 1 Oct 2026; file alongside the RD application.

b. Tests

- **SAT/ACT required** (confirm the 2026-27 line on Penn's testing page). Self-reported.
- IELTS/TOEFL **waived** (English-medium A-Levels — confirm on Penn's checklist).

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay + Penn supplement** (Penn-specific short essays).
- Confirm 2026-27 prompts at Common App open (~1 Aug 2026).

d. Application fee

- **USD 75**, or a **need-based fee waiver**.

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model — Need-AWARE for internationals** (limited intl-aid budget). A Malaysian-sponsor hedge matters here. Penn puts **over USD 10 million a year** into aid for students who aren't US/Canada/Mexico citizens.
- **Cost — USD 99,082/yr** all-in (~RM 404,000/yr) — **the priciest of your six** — tuition 65,670 · fees 8,308 · housing 13,644 · food 6,960 · books 1,412 · transportation 1,080 · personal 2,008.
- **Covers — 100% of demonstrated need**, once admitted-with-aid, using **grants + work-study — no loans**. Nothing Penn awards has to be repaid.
- **Your share**
 - Penn packages aid as a **shared investment**: every aided student carries an expected contribution, part of it met through **work-study** (Penn funds this for internationals out of its own money, so you can hold a campus job).
 - ⚠ **Penn does not publish the contribution amount** — unlike Yale's USD 3,700 or Stanford's ~USD 5,000. Budget for a comparable few thousand USD/yr and **ask Penn Student Financial Services for your figure** once you have an offer.
 - **Still yours**: visa + SEVIS fees, and spending beyond the allowance.
- **Forms — International CSS Profile** (Penn code **2933**).
- **Documents** — Parents' income + tax documents.
- **Dates — Critical: request aid WITH the application — it cannot be added after admission.**

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Common App + Penn supplement
- ☐ counselor + 2 teacher recs
- ☐ transcript + predicted grades
- ☐ **SAT (self-report)**
- ☐ **CSS Profile (code 2933) filed WITH the app** + parent tax docs
- ☐ request fee waiver

Portal: <https://admissions.upenn.edu/how-to-apply/first-year-applicants> · aid: <https://srfs.upenn.edu/financial-aid/international>

4. Harvard University — Reach — need-blind for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** REA **2026-11-01** · Regular Decision **2027-01-01**
- **Financial-aid deadline:** REA: **2026-11-01** · RD: **2027-02-01** (CSS Profile + [IDOC](#)).

b. Tests

- **SAT/ACT required.** Self-reported; scores needed by end **Nov** for REA (Dec SAT / Feb ACT accepted for RD).
- IELTS/TOEFL **waived** (English-medium A-Levels).

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay** + **Harvard supplement** (short questions).
- Confirm 2026-27 prompts at Common App open (~1 Aug 2026).

d. Application fee

- **No application fee** for international applicants (need-based waiver — request via Common App / Harvard).

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model — Need-blind for internationals** — requesting aid does **not** affect admission; same generous aid as US students.
- **Cost — USD 91,634/yr billed (~RM 374,000/yr)** — tuition 62,226 · fees 6,216 · housing 14,250 · food 8,942. With personal (2,500), books (1,000) and travel (0–5,000), the full figure is **USD 95,134–100,134/yr (~RM 388,000–409,000)**. Health insurance is a further USD 4,954 unless your family's plan covers you.
- **Covers — Everything, and it is the most complete offer of your six.** From 2025-26, families **under USD 100k pay nothing** (your band) — all billed costs (tuition, fees, housing, food) **plus health insurance, plus travel between Malaysia and campus, plus winter gear** (you will need it), plus a **USD 2,000 start-up grant** in year 1 and a **USD 2,000 launch grant** in your junior year. Expected parent contribution: **zero**.

- **Your share**

- **A term-time work expectation only** — Harvard **scrapped the summer-work expectation in 2020-21**, so your Malaysian summers stay free. Roughly **10–12 hrs/week** of campus work during term.
- ⚠ Harvard's own pages **disagree on the amount**: the financial-aid fact sheet says **USD 2,700/yr**, the affordability page says **~USD 3,500/yr**. Budget the higher one (~RM 14,000) and confirm on your award letter.
- You may replace the expectation with an outside award (a Malaysian sponsor counts) or a loan.
- **Still yours**: visa + SEVIS fees. Flights *are* covered.

- **Forms — CSS Profile + IDOC.**

- **Documents** — Parents' income + tax documents (uploaded via IDOC).

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Common App + Harvard supplement
- ☐ counselor + 2 teacher recs
- ☐ transcript + predicted grades
- ☐ **SAT (self-report)**
- ☐ CSS Profile + IDOC + parent tax docs

Portal: <https://college.harvard.edu/admissions/apply> · aid: <https://college.harvard.edu/financial-aid>

5. Yale University — Reach — need-blind for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** SCEA **2026-11-01** · Regular Decision **2027-01-02**
- **Financial-aid deadline:** Financial-aid documents filed with the application (SCEA by Nov / RD by early Feb — confirm on [finaid.yale.edu](https://financialaid.yale.edu)).

b. Tests

- **SAT/ACT REQUIRED (new this cycle)** — Yale's former test-flexible option (AP/IB accepted) ended; only SAT or ACT now. Self-reported.
- IELTS/TOEFL **waived** (English-medium A-Levels).

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay + Yale supplement** (several short-answer + short essays).
- Confirm 2026-27 prompts at Common App open (~1 Aug 2026).

d. Application fee

- **No application fee** for international applicants (need-based waiver — request via Common App / Yale).

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model — Need-blind for internationals** — requesting aid does **not** affect admission. Yale awards aid purely on need **regardless of citizenship or immigration status**.
- **Cost — USD 97,985/yr** all-in (~RM 400,000/yr) — tuition 72,500 (**the highest tuition of your six**) · housing 12,080 · food 9,520 · activities fee 185 · books 1,000 · personal 2,700. Yale adds a travel allowance **calculated per country**, so Malaysia is priced in.
- **Covers — The full ~RM 400k, for your band.** Under USD 100k household income with typical assets = **USD 0 parent share**. The Yale Scholarship covers **tuition, fees, housing, food and travel**, plus **hospitalization insurance** and a **USD 2,000 start-up grant** in your first year. Grants, **no loans**; the award explicitly **adjusts for the Malaysia-vs-US economy** in your favour.
- **Your share**
 - **The Student Share: USD 3,700/yr** (~RM 15,000) — the clearest figure of your six. It equals exactly the books + personal-expenses estimate, and you meet it with a term-time campus job.
 - **Still yours:** visa + SEVIS fees. Flights are inside the country-based travel allowance.
- **Forms — CSS Profile** (required of all international aid applicants).
- **Documents** — Parents' tax/income documents.

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Common App + Yale supplement
- ☐ counselor + 2 teacher recs
- ☐ transcript + predicted grades
- ☐ **SAT (self-report)**
- ☐ CSS Profile + parent tax docs

Portal: <https://admissions.yale.edu/apply> · aid: <https://finaid.yale.edu/apply/prospective>

MIT application (own portal, NOT Common App)

Universities: Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT).

Filed once across these schools:

- ☐ Apply on **MIT's own application** at mitadmissions.org — **NOT the Common App** (a separate account and separate essays).
- ☐ **MIT short-answer essays** (MIT-specific prompts, not the Common App essay).
- ☐ **Two evaluations:** one **maths/science** teacher + one **humanities/social-science/language** teacher, plus a **secondary school report + transcript** from your counselor.
- ☐ **Self-report SAT/ACT** (required).
- ☐ **English test:** recommended only if you've used English <5 years — your English-medium A-Levels qualify you to skip it (optional).

6. Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) — Reach — need-blind for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** [Early Action](#) **2026-11-01** · Regular Action **2027-01-05** (decisions mid-Dec / mid-March).
- **Financial-aid deadline:** CSS Profile + parent tax/income via **IDOC by 2027-02-15** (RA; EA applicants earlier).

b. Tests

- **SAT/ACT REQUIRED.** Take by **30 Nov 2026** (EA) / **31 Dec 2026** (RA). Self-reported.
- English test recommended only if English <5 yrs — your English-medium A-Levels qualify you to skip it.

c. Essays

- **MIT's own short-answer essays** on its portal (not the Common App essay).

d. Application fee

- **USD 75**, with a **need-based fee waiver** (no fee if you can't pay).

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model — Need-blind for internationals** — requesting aid does **not** affect admission.
- **Cost — USD 92,760/yr** all-in (~RM 378,000/yr) — **the cheapest sticker of your six** — tuition 66,720 · housing 14,090 · food 8,104 · student life fee 420 · books 930 · personal 2,496. A travel allowance is added on top, set by your home address.
- **Covers — All of it, for your band.** Under ~USD 100k family income = **USD 0 parent contribution** — MIT Scholarship **grants, no loans**. MIT's published median net price for the USD 0–100k band was **USD 0** in 2025-26, so 'effectively free if admitted' is MIT's own number, not a sales pitch.
- **Your share**
 - **You still contribute**, unlike Princeton. MIT expects a **summer-savings contribution + term-time campus work** on top of the zero parent contribution — so one Malaysian summer is spoken for.
 - ⚠ **MIT doesn't publish the amount** on its cost page; expect a few thousand USD/yr in line with its peers, and confirm on your award letter.
 - **Still yours:** visa + SEVIS fees, and spending beyond the allowance.
- **Forms — CSS Profile** + parental tax/income via **IDOC**.
- **Documents** — Parents' tax/income documents (uploaded via IDOC).

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ **MIT's own application** (separate account)
- ☐ MIT short essays
- ☐ counselor school report + transcript

- ☐ **2 teacher evals (1 math/science + 1 other)**
- ☐ **SAT (self-report)**
- ☐ CSS Profile + IDOC + parent tax docs

Portal: <https://mitadmissions.org/apply/firstyear/> · aid: <https://sfs.mit.edu/undergraduate-students/apply-for-aid/international/>

Gather once (across the whole region)

Gather these **once** — they serve all six applications: - ☐ **Your school's official transcript + predicted A-Level grades** (Maths, Further Maths, Physics, Chemistry). - ☐ **Recommenders lined up now:** 1 school counselor ([School Report](#)) + **2 teachers** — 1 maths/science + 1 other. The same three cover the [Common App](#) schools **and** MIT. - ☐ **SAT:** register early; sit it by **3 Oct 2026** if you want any early card, otherwise by **5 Dec 2026** for [Regular Decision](#). [Self-reported](#) everywhere. - ☐ **Essays:** 1 **Common App personal essay** (reused across the 5) + **each school's supplements** + **MIT's own essays** (separate). - ☐ **Financial aid:** create a [CSS Profile](#) account when it opens **1 Oct 2026**; set up [IDOC](#) (Harvard, MIT); file [PFAA](#) (Princeton); use [ISAFA](#) for Stanford if you can't pay the CSS fee; file **Penn's CSS with the application** (code 2933). - ☐ **Parents' income + tax documents, translated to English** — every aid form needs them. - ☐ **Passport** (for the [I-20](#) / visa step once admitted). - ☐ **Application fees:** four are free for internationals; only **Stanford (USD 90)** and **Penn (USD 75)** charge — **request need-based waivers**, so budget ≈ **USD 0**.

Deadline calendar

Date	What	Action
2026-10-01	CSS Profile opens	Start the aid form (all six); set up IDOC / PFAA / ISAFA as needed
2026-10-03	SAT — last comfortable sitting for an EARLY app	Sit the SAT if you'll apply early (Stanford REA needs an end-Oct score)
2026-11-01	EARLY deadline (pick ONE: Princeton SCEA / Stanford REA / Harvard REA / Yale SCEA / MIT EA)	Submit your single early application + aid
2026-11-01	Harvard REA financial-aid deadline	File CSS Profile + IDOC if applying Harvard REA
2026-11-15	Stanford REA aid priority deadline	File CSS Profile / ISAFA if applying Stanford REA
2026-11-30	MIT EA SAT cutoff	Take the SAT by now if applying MIT Early Action
2026-12-05		Sit the SAT for RD schools

Date	What	Action
	SAT — last practical sitting for Regular Decision	
2026-12-31	MIT RA / Stanford RD SAT cutoff	Take the SAT by end of Dec for Regular Decision/Action
2027-01-01	Regular deadline: Princeton RD + Harvard RD	Submit Common App + supplements + aid
2027-01-02	Yale Regular Decision	Submit Common App + Yale supplement + CSS Profile
2027-01-05	Regular deadline: Stanford RD + UPenn RD + MIT RA	Submit; for Penn, file CSS WITH the application
2027-02-01	Harvard RD financial-aid deadline	File CSS Profile + IDOC
2027-02-15	MIT financial-aid deadline	Submit CSS Profile + parental docs via IDOC
2027-05-01	Enrollment reply date (all US)	Compare offers + aid, then decide

Sources

- [Princeton — Application Dates & Deadlines / Standardized Testing / Aid](#) — Official — as of 2027
- [Stanford — First-Year Deadlines, Testing & International Aid \(ISAFA\)](#) — Official — as of 2027
- [UPenn — First-Year Applicants + International Financial Aid \(CSS code 2933\)](#) — Official — as of 2027
- [UPenn — International Student Financial Aid \(aid requested with the application\)](#) — Official — as of 2027
- [Harvard — First-Year Applicants + Financial Aid \(need-blind, no loans\)](#) — Official — as of 2027
- [Harvard — International application fee waiver](#) — Official — as of 2027
- [Yale — Deadlines & platforms + new SAT/ACT testing requirement \(May 2026\)](#) — Official — as of 2027
- [Yale — International students financial aid \(CSS Profile, need-blind\)](#) — Official — as of 2027
- [MIT — Deadlines & requirements + SAT/ACT reinstated](#) — Official — as of 2027
- [MIT — International students financial aid \(CSS + IDOC, need-blind\)](#) — Official — as of 2027
- [College Board — Fall-2026 SAT dates & deadlines \(international\)](#) — Official — as of 2027
- [Princeton — The Student Budget \(2026-27 cost of attendance\)](#) — Official — as of 2026-27
- [Princeton — enhanced aid: under USD 100k full cost, student contribution eliminated](#) — Official — as of 2026-27
- [Stanford — Undergraduate student budget 2026-27](#) — Official — as of 2026-27

- [Stanford — Student Responsibility \(the ~USD 5,000 student contribution\)](#) — Official — as of 2026-27
- [UPenn — Undergraduate cost of attendance 2026-27 \(USD 99,082\)](#) — Official — as of 2026-27
- [Harvard — Cost of attendance + how aid works 2026-27 \(USD 91,634 billed\)](#) — Official — as of 2026-27
- [Harvard — Affordability: under USD 100k pay nothing, incl. travel + start-up/launch grants](#) — Official — as of 2026-27
- [Harvard — FAS Registrar tuition & fees 2026-27 \(line items\)](#) — Official — as of 2026-27
- [Yale — Cost of attendance 2026-27 \(USD 97,985\)](#) — Official — as of 2026-27
- [Yale — Affordability: USD 0 parent share under USD 100k; Student Share USD 3,700](#) — Official — as of 2026-27
- [MIT — Cost of attendance 2026-27 \(USD 92,760\)](#) — Official — as of 2026-27
- [MIT — Making MIT affordable \(under USD 100k = parents pay nothing; student contribution\)](#) — Official — as of 2026-27